tower; the lamplighter was ‘dashed into a thousand pieces’.

Maybe it wasn’t nostalgia that occupied Akbar’s evenings; maybe it was fury. For a half-century, Akbar had nurtured an empire: growing it from the fields of Kalanaur to the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal, across the Himalayan snows and the Vindhyan plateaus. Could he not have hoped, at the end of his days, for a suitable heir, just one son who wasn’t greedy for wine or impatient for power?

Like a wounded beast slashing at anything that moves, Akbar hurled invective at the mansabdars who now scurried into court. Among them was Khwaja Amiruddin, whose turn it was to keep the watch. After ‘abusing and disgracing him’, Akbar ordered him to leave ‘instantly . . . and join the Prince’s camp’. (Presumably, he meant Salim, and to suggest that only the riff-raff from amongst his mansabdars had allied with the prince in Allahabad.) Daulat Khan, also on guard duty, was ‘disgraced and dishonoured’; then came Ram Das’s turn. But Akbar’s temper was cooling: Ram Das ‘was not so severely punished’.

Akbar sat down on his throne, and Asad Beg approached, trembling. In fact, the interview went better than he might have feared. Akbar’s anger dissolved quickly, and Asad had so many stories to tell: not least that of the Bijapuri elephant that had grown accustomed to a daily drink. Asad Beg, escorting the animal to Akbar as a gift from the Deccani kingdom, had to supply its needs from crates of expensive Portuguese wine.

Asad Beg had brought other gifts from Bijapur too, including a pipe, lighter and pouch of tobacco. The pipe was ‘beautifully dried and coloured, both ends being adorned with jewels and enamel’, its oval mouthpiece made of cornelian. The lighter was ‘golden . . . as a proper accompaniment’. And the tobacco – a Portuguese import and never before seen in court – was of the best quality, said Asad, having arranged the whole kit ‘on a silver tray’.

Akbar’s curiosity was aroused. Even more than the novelty of tobacco, he may have enjoyed the brief but energetic debate that followed the lighting of the pipe. The emperor, always keen to try his hand at things, took a few puffs, but his doctor, ‘in great trouble’ by his side, stopped him. Aziz, once again the emperor’s companion on his adventures, had a go. Aziz summoned his own ‘druggist’, too, who had heard about this ‘new invention . . . and [said that] the European doctors had written much in its